



Closing in: The victory was not just the culmination of a perfect weekend for the Red Bull Racing driver, but a clear statement that Verstappen is well and truly in the driver's title picture, perhaps even the frontrunner for the crown. GETTY IMAGES

STILL IN THE HUNT

Max Verstappen is scripting one of Formula One's great comebacks, his latest victory bringing him within **striking distance** of the battling McLaren duo.

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The emphatic stage dive into the waiting mechanics in parc fermé was the only time Max Verstappen had to stretch his muscles in Austin. The 28-year-old dominated the United States Grand Prix from lights to flag, finishing almost eight seconds ahead of McLaren's Lando Norris to register his 68th career win in Formula One.

The victory at the Circuit of the Americas (COTA) was not just the culmination of a perfect weekend for the Red Bull Racing driver, but a clear statement that the Dutchman is well and truly in the driver's title picture, perhaps even the frontrunner for the crown.

With five rounds remaining, Verstappen sits just 40 points behind championship leader Oscar Piastri, who could only manage a fifth-place finish in Texas. Verstappen has clawed back 64 points

on the Australian in the last four races, meaning a fifth consecutive drivers' title is no longer a distant dream.

Two weeks on from his second-place finish through the streets of Singapore, Verstappen started the weekend on the front foot, clinching pole position for the Sprint Race just ahead of the two McLarens. It was another opportunity for the Dutch driver to eat into the points deficit in the